Full Proposal – To Build a Nation's Heart

Nation-Building through Participation, Service, and Shared Culture

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Introduction

Humanity's progress has brought us to a crossroads: the existential threats that defined our ancestors have receded, even as a new set of emotional and psychological challenges presses on daily life. These include deep isolation, depression, the absence of real-life (or "true") friends—even with online lists full of strangers—panic induced by a seemingly never-ending daily grind, hopelessness, and, above all, a lack of purpose.

This sense of an exhausting, endless grind—with happiness always out of reach—has left many people bitter, emotionally drained, and less willing to reason critically amid pervasive misinformation and disinformation. It makes them easier to sway by superficial means. This becomes most visible during elections, when some will choose a different party simply because they are bored with the incumbent. They do not feel a stake in nation-building and think the least they can do is give "the other side" a chance. Their thought becomes: *"Maybe something will change this time…"* Politics begins to resemble a television show in which the next season might be better than the last.

"When citizens move from spectators to builders, cynicism recedes and purpose returns."

Our goal is to restore trust—in the work of our leaders, in the way the system works—and to give people a genuine stake in the nation-building process. Above all, we must return a sense of purpose. Once citizens begin to feel even a sliver of these changes in their own lives, hope, belonging, and purpose follow. That is what brings people together to rally behind leaders they know—and into whom they have invested their sweat and tears—rather than late-arriving voices showering the public with flowery words and last-minute promises.

There are many ways to strengthen our country. Today, we bring forward three ways that promise long-term strength at Canada's core and that also reinforce one another. They are

present behind the success of every strong nation—and, when absent, behind national decline: **Building People, Building Force and Building Spirit**

Building People

Action Items

- Realize that different people have different interests and differ widely in their physical, mental, and emotional stamina. (For example, someone who could excel as a nurse might not thrive in a social kitchen, and a fantastic gardener might not be a good manager.) – *"I would really like to contribute my time to a program if they did XYZ."*
- **Create a diverse range of social volunteer programs** that people can join, and tie every program back to the overall goal of nation-building. – *"If I join this program, I know I can meaningfully contribute to the nation-building process."*
- **Create incentivization for these programs**. Incentives offered through multiple mechanisms that lower barriers to entry, make contributions visible and rewarding, and sustain participation over time. In practice, incentives should do three jobs:
    - Using public media to advertise opportunities. – *"I have no clue what all programs are there that I might want to join."*
    - Incentivizing businesses to pass part of the benefits to participants (e.g., discounts, memberships). – *"My work doesn't just help the nation and community; it also has these perks for me and my family that I really enjoy!"*
    - Volunteer does not mean no funds. Inject capital into programs through national policy to signal leadership support and keep initiatives active. Use simple, performance-based tiers (full/partial/matching) with funds released when targets are met—not by perceived social impact alone. Programs that are temporarily unfunded should continue as volunteer-led and remain eligible for future support once they perform. – *"I know what I do is important, because leadership is invested in it. We have funds, but we are also frugal with them to ensure their best use."*

- **Celebrate the people who join and work in these programs**. Few want to spend their lives working in the dark; recognition matters. – *"My team won first place among all the counties in Ontario in the number of trees planted and managed!"*
- **Create a transparent and attractive nationwide portal to show results across programs**. Use statistical methods to help citizens see their contribution to the nation-building process and to their local community. – *"My work is important for nation-building, and I know exactly why."*
- **Promote from within program ranks**. People want a story; give them a chance to shape one. (Their day job does not have to be their life's story.) – *"I started as a nobody in this program and I learned so much. I retired as the national director of the program. That is my legacy."*
- **Create a culture of mentorship**. Some people retire; others want to pass their knowledge to the next generation. Make mentors first-class citizens in program design. – *"I have retired but I have these young kids to teach the subtle points of how to do this well. I am happy that all I have learned will not be lost!"*
- **Resist the pressure and stay away from false praises**. Falsely praising almost no or mediocre achievement sets a poor example in multiple ways: first, it offends people who truly worked hard and achieved something exceptional; second, it lowers trust in the system's capacity to hit targets by creating the impression that any achievement may be an exaggeration of something small or insignificant.

Results

- People form bonds as close as family.
- People understand who is really driving change in the country.
- People become hard (almost impossible) to sway by flowery speeches or rallies alone.

- People's work in the program of their choice becomes part of their identity.
- The political agency behind the initial work disappears and is replaced by a true will to build the nation. This is reflected in the restoration of faith in the political leadership leading the change.
- Over time, the leadership driving this change needs fewer volunteers to spread the message; everyone working within the programs becomes a believer in the goodness of the leadership's objectives.

"Volunteerism becomes identity when contribution is visible, measured, and celebrated."

Building Force: Armed Forces Recruitment

Being peaceful is not weak, being proud is not ego and being strong is not belligerence. Calm, considered strength is what parents teach their children, and what the Canadian Armed Forces have embodied on the world stage for more than a century.

Generations of Canadian families have entrusted their sons and daughters to the Armed Forces. Those men and women have contributed immensely to the safety and functioning of this nation, both on active duty and later in the civilian workforce.

> **"Modern defence needs mid-career mastery; our rules must welcome it, not repel it."**

That said, Canada faces distinct recruitment challenges:

- A relatively small population for a vast geography.
- Negative perceptions of military life, especially amid changing socio-economic values around inclusion.
- Intense global competition for qualified candidates.
- Slow, outdated recruitment processes that fail to attract new talent.

Below are two reforms that would directly improve recruitment.

Look to the future, not the past

Modern defence is increasingly technology centred. The edge now comes from advanced networking, robotics, avionics, cyber capabilities, and decision systems. These are domains that demand years of practice on real systems. In reality, many of the best candidates reach peak capability only after a long on-ramp of education and experience, often landing in their mid-30s or 40s. Our policies should reflect this. When the institution is designed around early-career entrants alone, mid-career experts, who are precisely the people we need, see the door as effectively closed.

> **"Technology, not headcount, wins the next fight."**

Pensions, in Plain Language

The current pension structure expects long service and specific age thresholds for an unreduced pension. A mid-career specialist who considers joining around age 40 usually cannot accumulate enough service time by age 60 to qualify. Unless they serve to 60, their pension is reduced; retiring earlier reduces it further. Meanwhile, someone who joined at 25 may retire at 55 with full coverage. While each rule has its internal logic, to outside candidates this feels imbalanced and discourages patriotic mid-career switches into the Forces.

Action Items

- **Extend retirement eligibility for technology-focused roles** to reflect today's longer, healthier working lives and the longer runway to mastery in technical domains.

> **"Patriotism should not require a pension penalty."**

- **Modernize the pension formula** so it accounts for age and career stage at entry, enabling mid-career experts to serve without facing automatic, steep reductions.

Results

- It becomes materially easier for experienced talent to join the Armed Forces — especially in science and technology roles where significant prior experience is essential.

Lack of Awareness and Respect

Children are impressionable, yet the good work of the Armed Forces is not sufficiently visible to the youngest in our population. For many families, especially among new Canadians, the culture they encounter at home may predominantly reflect countries of origin. This can slow or, at times, block immersion in Canadian civic identity and make the Armed Forces feel distant or irrelevant.

> **"Peace is strongest when its guardians are known and respected."**

Today, many young Canadians are never meaningfully introduced to military life. Reasons include a strong societal emphasis on formal education and employment, and decades in which national leadership placed limited public focus on the Forces under the umbrella of Canada being a peaceful country. As noted earlier, being peaceful should not mean being weak; earnest effort is needed to ensure national defence is not overlooked.

Action Items

- **Introduce youth programs** that teach values aligned with the Armed Forces such as independence, management, problem-solving, leadership, and entrepreneurship, building these capabilities at an early age.
- **Consider a mandatory national service period** for everyone below a set age threshold. This would introduce many to a lifestyle they might otherwise never consider, provide basic survival training for all, and bring a fresh wave of ideas (and challenges) into the Forces each year, giving the institution better visibility into the needs of the current populace and reducing negative or mistaken perceptions.
- **Provide incentives across society** that showcase contributions of, and pathways into, the Forces, for example, Armed Forces schools and colleges, hospitals, social events, food charities, and similar civic touchpoints.

- **Keep the Forces visible** in schools (on appropriate occasions), public spaces, tournaments (with Forces teams participating), festivals, skills displays, and community events. Small but memorable moments keep the image of the Armed Forces alive as national defenders.

Results

- Early, recurring exposure makes military life familiar and respected; the Cabadian Armed Forces (CAF) is seen as a viable, honourable option rather than distant or misunderstood.
- Youth programs measurably build leadership, resilience, problem-solving, and teamwork; participation rates and completion certificates rise year over year.
- If implemented, a national-service period establishes a shared civic baseline; basic survival and emergency-response skills become near-universal in the 18–25 cohort.
- The perception gap narrows among newcomer families; applications from immigrant communities increase and retention improves due to informed, eyes-open choices.
- Continued public presence (schools, festivals, tournaments, skills displays) lifts positive recognition and trust; national survey scores for “respect for the CAF” trend upward.
- Stronger community links (colleges, hospitals, charities) create a virtuous circle of visibility, service, and pride.

Stronger Immigration Checks and Prioritized Paths

Ours is a nation built through immigration. As the world grows more globalized, some newcomers may not fully recognize the duty to contribute to the nation or to become Canadian "at heart and mind" after naturalization. Instead, they may remain citizens of their country of origin at heart while being Canadians on paper. Such detachment weakens social cohesion. These individuals may not contribute to nation-building and may even discourage those who wish to do so.

Action Items

- **Strengthen immigration checks** so that individuals with dubious motives do not pass – for example, by setting clear language proficiency thresholds.
- **Regularly audit the immigration process**; ineffective screening can admit individuals who undermine collective effort.
- **Treat residence as probationary until naturalization,** with policies that allow authorities to revoke status if basic requirements, such as language, civil behaviour, and orderly conduct, etc. are not met.
- **Tie naturalization to contribution, not time alone.** Beyond minimum years, require evidence of nation-building performance (e.g., service through national programs or the Armed Forces, or significant cultural, technological, or community contributions attested by multiple rotating endorsers). In principle, those misaligned with the nation's goals and mindset could remain in residence status for extended periods (or up to a well-defined maximum) without naturalization.

Results

- Naturalization more clearly signals commitment and contribution; civic behaviour aligns with Canadian norms and expectations.

- Language and conduct thresholds accelerate labour-market integration and reduce administrative churn.
- Contribution-linked pathways (Armed Forces, national programs, cultural/technological/community leadership) draw higher participation; net contribution per newcomer cohort rises.
- Fewer instances of "on-paper-only" citizenship; social cohesion strengthens and non-compliance incidents decline.
- Canada's reputation for seriousness and fairness attracts high-calibre immigrants who seek belonging in both rights **and** responsibilities; time from arrival to meaningful contribution shortens.
- Proportionate, transparent enforcement improves public trust while protecting genuine newcomers from stigma.

These stronger rules make the nation both resilient and desirable. High-calibre individuals abroad will see Canada's seriousness in maintaining and raising the quality of civic life and will be attracted to immigrate – not only on paper, but in heart and contribution.

"Citizenship must be earned in heart and habit, not paperwork alone."

Building Spirit: Patriotism

Lack of a Canadian Culture

There is a severe lack of a culture that Canada can call its own. For the longest time, we have been called a melting pot of cultures. However, in practice some cultures are not "melting"; they take root in separate communities and can exert negative influence on young or more impressionable people. Tackling this requires a **two-fold** approach.

Canada needs to recognize its heritage as a nation of settlers that stands on the shoulders of First Nations communities. Our history as a nation cannot be separate from those who were here before us. To be a true "melting pot," settler and immigrant cultures should blend into the rich First Nations cultures to create something uniquely Canadian and carry it into the twenty-first century. This is our true inheritance: humility, grace, and ancient values, alongside hard work, grit, and a forward-looking spirit.

> **"From 'us' and 'them' to our elders—one story, one country."**

Although there have been attempts to bridge the gap between these cultures, newcomers to this land still seem lost. In our land acknowledgements, we thank those who welcomed us and yet can feel as if we have thanked someone else. It is still "us" thanking "them." It has not yet transcended to the feeling of being one. When true melting occurs, we simply respect **our** elders and carry a richer culture forward together. Over the last hundred years, many other cultures have also contributed to this nation. Only through collective recognition of all these cultures can the pot become warm enough to melt into something truly Canadian.

Action Items

- Surface prominent cultural events from First Nations at a national level.
- Encourage cultural immersion through traditional activities such as ceremonies, arts and crafts (e.g., boat building), and culinary practices.

- Seek out and highlight significant Canadian art and literature in different communities.
- For literature, it should not matter whether it is in First Nations languages or the languages of immigrant communities such as English, French, Chinese, Hindi, Korean, Punjabi, etc. As long as it is about Canada, it is meaningful.

Results

- National visibility of First Nations cultural events increases; participation and broadcast reach grow year over year.
- More Canadians, across communities, engage in shared practices (ceremonies, crafts, cuisine), creating common reference points and symbols.
- Canadian arts and literature in multiple languages gain wider distribution; libraries, schools, and festivals feature Canadian-themed works more prominently.
- Surveyed sense of belonging and “shared Canadian identity” trends upward across age and newcomer cohorts.

Lack of Cultural Immersion for Kids and Young Adults

A large part of the current Canadian population is composed of children of new immigrants; this makes cultural immersion especially important. In many homes, as soon as the child returns home from school, they are immersed primarily in the culture of their parents' country of origin. This can slow, or in some cases block, immersion in Canadian culture and result in a less-than-optimal Canadian identity as an adult.

> **"Belonging is learned young; put Canadian stories in young hands."**

Action Items

- Introduce more national-identity-focused subjects or content (e.g., stories, poems, histories) in schools to foster belonging at an earlier age.
- As the nation builds a shared cultural identity (from the previous step), embed it in the educational curriculum so that it sits in the hearts and minds of students.
- Extend the curriculum to include concepts that help students resist cultural "wash-over" at home. The goal is to respect and understand their parents' heritage while affirming that they are Canadian and should act and think in ways reflective of this nation's values.

Results

- Earlier formation of Canadian civic identity; classroom assessments show improved knowledge of Canadian stories, symbols, and history.
- Increased student participation in local cultural events and cross-cultural projects; schools report higher engagement with Canadian-themed activities.
- Youth report greater confidence reconciling respect for family heritage with a clear, positive Canadian identity.

Tightening the Separation of Canadian Public Life and Religion/Faiths

Religion is a deeply personal phenomenon that everyone has the right to exercise and experience. History also shows that religion can be used in ways beyond the personal spiritual experience it is meant to be. Overt religious expression in public life can offend others and, more importantly, divert public interest from nation-building and economic development toward division or negativity.

> **"Neutral public spaces protect every faith — and the nation we share."**

Leadership should make a conscious effort to recognize the importance of separation between Canadian Public Life (CPL) and the practice of religion or faiths. Such a separation should be established at the policy level and percolated into legal frameworks across federal, provincial, county, and city levels. Law-enforcement authorities should be empowered under such policies to mitigate any escalation from overt religious expression into extremist behaviour and to ensure that the daily rhythm of a healthy nation is not disrupted by overtly religious ambitions of a few.

Action Items

- Establish clear CPL policies that reinforce neutrality in public institutions and civic events, with consistent application across jurisdictions.
- Provide guidance and training for officials on proportionate, rights-respecting enforcement that prevents escalation while protecting freedom of belief and private worship.
- Clarify permitting and use-of-space rules for public venues to avoid ad hoc decisions that create perceptions of bias.
- Establish a clear, public policy governing the use of public spaces for religious or faith-based expression that protects neutrality and sets visibly fair, uniform practices applicable to all faiths and none.

Results

- Fewer instances of sectarian friction in civic spaces; public confidence in neutrality of institutions increases.
- Clearer rules reduce disputes over venues, signage, and events; permitting timelines and satisfaction scores improve.
- Communities report feeling safer and more included in public life; multi-faith participation in civic events rises within a neutral, unifying public square.
- Public spaces operate under transparent, uniformly applied rules; perceptions of bias fall, ad hoc disputes decrease, and compliance and satisfaction improve across faith and non-faith communities.

“Melt into one: First Nations at the foundation, every community in the weave.”

Conclusion and Policy Call-to-Action

> **“Give every citizen a way to say, ‘I helped build this.’”**

Canada has the people, the decency, and the institutions to thrive. What has been missing is a shared sense of purpose and clear, visible ways for every person to contribute. This proposal answers that need. **Building People** invites Canadians into structured, dignified work that becomes part of their identity. **Building Force** modernizes how we attract and retain talent so the Canadian Armed Forces can embody calm strength in a technology-centred age. **Building Spirit** forges a cultural confidence rooted in First Nations heritage and open to every community that now calls Canada home. Together, these pillars reinforce each other: participation builds trust; trust enables service; shared culture sustains both.

The effects are practical as well as moral. When citizens see their effort credited and their progress measured, cynicism recedes and resilience grows. When mid-career experts can serve without penalty, capability rises where it is most needed. When Canadian stories are lived in schools, libraries, festivals, and public life—and when neutrality in our civic square is protected—belonging deepens. The result is a more cohesive society, less vulnerable to misinformation and performative politics, and more willing to stand with leaders who deliver steady, visible progress.

Turning this vision into lived reality requires partnership across governments, Indigenous leadership, civil society, business, and communities. It asks for transparency in how programs are funded and evaluated; fairness and seriousness in immigration and naturalization; and rights-respecting neutrality in the use of public space. None of this diminishes diversity. Rather, it channels the energy of a diverse country toward a common good and a confident future.

The opportunity is generational. By inviting Canadians to move from spectators to builders, we can renew the nation's heart and leave a sturdier country to our children. **Let us lead with calm strength—and give every citizen a clear way to say: "I helped build this."**

"Participation builds trust; shared culture sustains it."